



Monday, April 27, 2026

To DC Council Members:

I am writing as Chair of the [Multimodal Accessibility Advisory Council](#) (MAAC), established under D.C. Official Code § 50-2361.31, which serves as the advisory body to the Mayor, the Council, and the District on making local transit and public space in the District more accessible to persons with disabilities, to request that any legislation permitting testing and providing automated vehicle (AV) passenger service include requirements for accessibility for disabled customers.

The DC Department of Transportation (DDOT) released a report on April 15, 2026: [Research Report on the State of AV Policy](#) that highlights findings on accessibility concerns and specifies recommendations. For example, see page 8:

“However, only some of those with mobility limitations can benefit from AVs unless the vehicles are wheelchair accessible vehicles (WAVs) and ensure safe entry and exit (D’Agnostino et al., 2024b; Congressional Research Service (CRS), 2025). How to provide services that equitably serve all communities well continues to be a key topic of discussion. D’Agnostino et al. (2024b) highlights concerns from disability advocates around vehicle design, interactions with blind pedestrians, and inadequate wheelchair-accessible AV options. The literature suggests requiring AV companies to meet accessibility benchmarks as a condition of operation.

Ehsani et al. (2024) demonstrates empirically that public trust in AVs increases when messaging emphasizes benefits for vulnerable populations and underserved communities. Multiple sources call for mandatory equity requirements, including:

- *Accessibility standards (wheelchair-accessible AVs);*
- *Deployment footprints that include underserved areas;*
- *Pricing transparency and protections against discriminatory practices;*
- *and*
- *Stakeholder engagement with disability and advocacy groups.”*



Most critically, requirements for accessible AV passenger service must be implemented from the start in order for the service to be equitable for disabled people.

This must include fully accessible vehicles (including for wheelchairs or use of wheelchair accessible vehicles also known as WAVs), app for ordering and engaging with the service, and interfaces within the vehicle. This must NOT include “referral to an outside provider” like a taxi service, because taxis in the District are still not meeting accessibility requirements established by DC Council a decade ago and are still not fully accessible for disabled passengers (See coverage from [WAMU](#), [The Wash](#), and [NBC4](#) regarding ongoing accessible taxi failures in DC).

Disability advocates are greatly concerned about AV companies pushing legislation through DC Council to allow testing and implementation of AV passenger service without requiring baseline accessibility requirements because (1) this has not been done in other jurisdictions and it is resulting in growth of yet another inaccessible and/or segregated transportation service for disabled people when a “referral service” is implemented and fails to provide equal offerings (limited accessible vehicles, service hours, etc); and (2) because retrofitting public transportation across the United States (see the history of bus, train/rail, and air travel, which is still very inaccessible for many) takes decades or never happens at all. The pattern is that if accessibility is not implemented from the start, it is very hard to achieve later, takes a very long time, or may never happen (see the New York City subway as another example, which may never become fully accessible). A [2024 market study](#) estimates 40 million people live in the US with some kind of disability, and that the market is sizable for these individuals as far as transportation/travel needs. In general, disabled people are very interested in safe and accessible AV service because a high percentage of this population does not drive and experience significant gaps and challenges with transportation. Having an accessible service to address these issues would be transformative in their lives for employment, commerce, and traveling to medical appointments.

Accessible AV transportation options would support economic development with access to employment opportunities for people with disabilities, per a study from the [National Disability Institute](#).



The National Council on Disability recently issued a detailed [report on the many ground transportation issues experienced by people with disabilities](#). (The [press release provides a good summary](#).) In short, lack of accessible ground transportation not only limits disabled people in employment opportunities and ability to participate freely in their communities, but suppresses overall US economic growth by excluding a significant portion of the population. (A chapter on the challenges of AVs and possible solutions for accessibility starts on page 103 of the report.)

The DC MAAC recommends two concepts be included in any AV legislation to be considered by DC Council:

1. A general requirement for compliance of nondiscrimination laws that includes specific reference of people with disabilities in providing equitable passenger AV service; and
2. A requirement that all AV service providers must provide accessible service directly (specifically not a 'referral to another service'), including: a wheelchair-accessible vehicle (WAV) fleet minimum of 10% at launch, scaling to 25% by year three and 50% by year five of operation, with milestones enforceable through service penalties and/or permit non-renewal; provision of an accessible app compliant with WCAG 2.1/2.2 Level AA standards; and an accessible onboard interface for emergencies in the vehicle.

Since this is a new and developing technology and service, it would be advisable that legislation also requires that whatever DC government agency appointed to regulate companies providing AV passenger service (such as DDOT or the Department for Hired Vehicles) engage regularly with disabled stakeholders (either by attending DC MAAC meetings or convening an advisory group) and act on recommendations they may provide for improving service.

MAAC further recommends that any AV legislation explicitly permit and encourage pilots of automated transit buses and shuttles, including extensions of the 2025-2026 Beep/Adastec pilot conducted in partnership with USDOT. Low-floor transit buses are already wheelchair accessible by design, making automated transit the category of AV service where accessibility is most readily achieved and most directly beneficial to disabled riders. Automated shuttles additionally offer a promising first- and last-mile solution for residents in areas underserved by Metrorail and Metrobus, including many neighborhoods east of the Anacostia River. The DDOT report (April 15, 2026) documents that shuttle pilots face genuine operational challenges around weather, speed, and ridership, and for that reason MAAC recommends the legislation authorize and support such pilots rather than mandate them -- with a requirement that pilot outcomes be reported to MAAC and to the Council.



We hope that you take these recommendations under advisement and implement them with the care and thoughtfulness the disability community has taken to research and recommend them. The DC MAAC is open for questions and ongoing engagement on this topic, vital for the future of accessible transportation in the city.

Regards,
DC MAAC